



Whooping Cough (Pertussis) in California

Current Status



Note. From Whooping Cough [Infographic], by CDC, 2024, ABC News. (<https://abcnews.go.com/GMA/Wellness/parents-whooping-cough-cases-surge/story?id=114774431>).

Whooping cough, also known as pertussis, is a highly contagious respiratory infection caused by *Bordetella pertussis*. In California, cases have surged significantly in 2024.

- As of November, 1,744 cases reported statewide (compared to <300 in 2023).
- Why:** Waning immunity and incomplete vaccination.

Clinical Symptoms

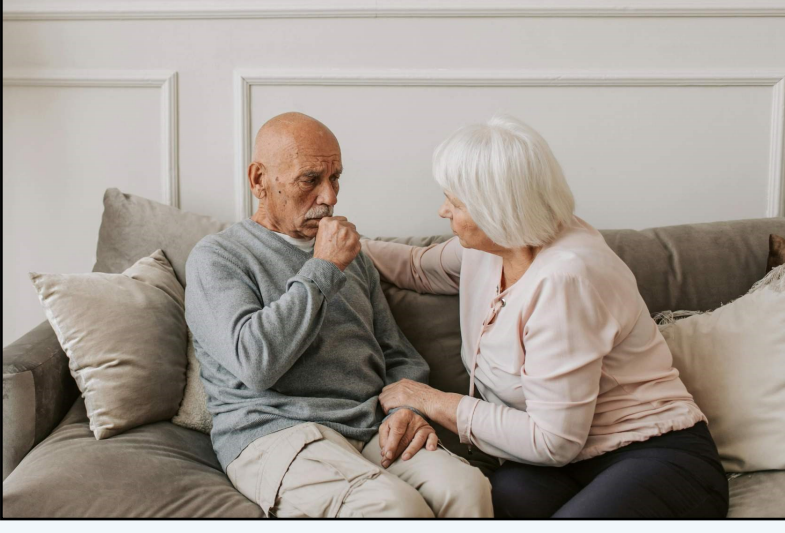
- Catarrhal Stage:** Cold-like symptoms, minimal fever, lasts 1-2 weeks.
- Paroxysmal Stage:** Severe coughing spasms with whooping sound, post-tussive vomiting, lasts 1-6 weeks.
- Convalescent Stage:** Gradual recovery, cough may persist.
- The hallmark symptom is the “whooping” sound during cough bouts, though this may be absent in some individuals, particularly infants and adults. Severe cases can lead to pneumonia, apnea, and, in infants, potentially fatal complications.

Transmission

- Highly contagious via inhalation of respiratory droplets.
- Infectious Period:** From onset of symptoms until 5 days of treatment or 21 days without treatment.

When to Treat

- Clinical Case Definition**
- In the absence of a more likely diagnosis, a cough illness lasting >2 weeks with at least one of the following:
- Paroxysms of coughing
 - Inspiratory “whoop”
 - Post-tussive vomiting
 - Apnea (with or without cyanosis)
- Probable Case Definition**
- In the absence of a more likely diagnosis, illness meeting the clinical criteria, OR
- Illness with cough of any duration, with at least one of the following signs or symptoms:
 - Paroxysms of coughing
 - Inspiratory whoop
 - Post-tussive vomiting
 - Apnea (with or without cyanosis), AND
 - Contact with a laboratory-confirmed case (epidemiologic linkage)



Laboratory Testing

PCR is preferred, especially within the first 3 weeks of cough. PCRs require in-person assessments.

Treatment

- Antibiotics:** Macrolides, such as azithromycin or clarithromycin, are the standard treatment, effectively reducing disease transmission if started early.
- Azithromycin
 - Infants under 6 months:** 10 mg/kg once daily for 5 days.
 - Infants 6 months and older, children, and adults:**
 - Day 1:** 10 mg/kg (maximum 500 mg) once.
 - Days 2-5:** 5 mg/kg (maximum 250 mg) once daily.
 - Clarithromycin
 - Children:** 15 mg/kg per day divided into 2 doses (maximum 1,000 mg/day) for 7 days.
 - Adults:** 500 mg twice daily for 7 days.

Supportive Care: In severe cases, particularly for infants, hospitalization may be required for respiratory support.

Prophylaxis Recommendations

- DTaP** for infants and young children.
- Tdap booster** for adolescents, adults, and during every pregnancy (preferably between 27-36 weeks gestation).
- Post-exposure antibiotics:** Close contacts of pertussis cases should receive prophylactic antibiotics, particularly in households with vulnerable individuals (infants, pregnant women, or immunocompromised persons).

Current Pediatric Recommendations

- If a child is treated for pneumonia on amoxicillin and not improving, azithromycin should be considered.
- Please do not treat pneumonia without an in-person evaluation.

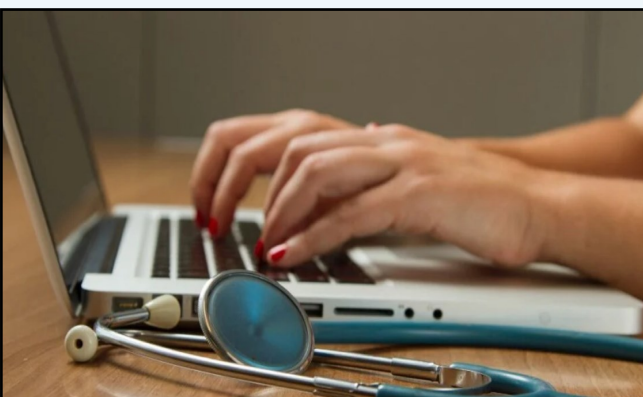
Raising public awareness about vaccination and timely booster doses remains critical to preventing future outbreaks.

People of all ages need WHOOPING COUGH VACCINES

DTaP for young children	Tdap for preteens	Tdap for pregnant women	Tdap for adults
✓ 2, 4, and 6 months ✓ 15 through 18 months ✓ 4 through 6 years	✓ 11 through 12 years	✓ During the 27-36th week of each pregnancy	✓ Anytime for those who have never received it

www.cdc.gov/whoopingcough

Introducing the GPC Mailbag!



At GPC Clinical Corner, we strive to provide tips on the best clinical practices, navigating patient encounters, and updated information on treatment options.

This year, we'd like to expand our scope to include your suggestions. We're proud to announce the GPC Mailbag, where you can request topics for discussion, or even specific questions, that you'd like to see in a future newsletter. You can reach us at GPCMailbag@kp.org. We look forward to hearing from you!

References

California Department of Public Health. (2024). Pertussis (whooping cough). <https://www.cdph.ca.gov/Programs/CID/DCDC/pages/immunization/pertussis.aspx>

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (2024). Whooping Cough [Infographic]. What parents need to know as whooping cough cases surge. ABC News, <https://abcnews.go.com/GMA/Wellness/parents-whooping-cough-cases-surge/story?id=114774431>

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